

The Barrier Reef



THE BIGGEST coral reef in the world is the Great Barrier Reef, which stretches nearly 1,250 miles (2,000 km) along the northeastern coast of Australia. Over millions of years, the limestone skeletons of tiny animals called corals build up on top of one another to make a reef.

Reefs form only in warm, salty waters that are shallow enough for sunlight to reach the corals. Many plants and animals can feed and grow on a reef. The Great Barrier Reef is home to a large variety of creatures, including more than 1,500 species of fish, 1,400 species of coral, and many types of sponges.

Hinged shell

The giant clam weighs up to 550 lbs (250 kg). Its shell is in two parts, joined by a hinge. The clam usually opens its shell so that it can feed, but can quickly close the shell in the face of danger. Clams can live for hundreds of years.

Giant clam (*Tridacna*)
Width of shell: up to 4 ft 6 in (1.4 m)



Attractive patterns

The bright colors and patterns of butterflyfishes help them recognize each other and attract mates. Each kind of butterflyfish has its own place on the reef and feeds on a different food.

Threadfin butterflyfish (*Chaetodon auriga*)
Length: up to 9 in (23 cm)

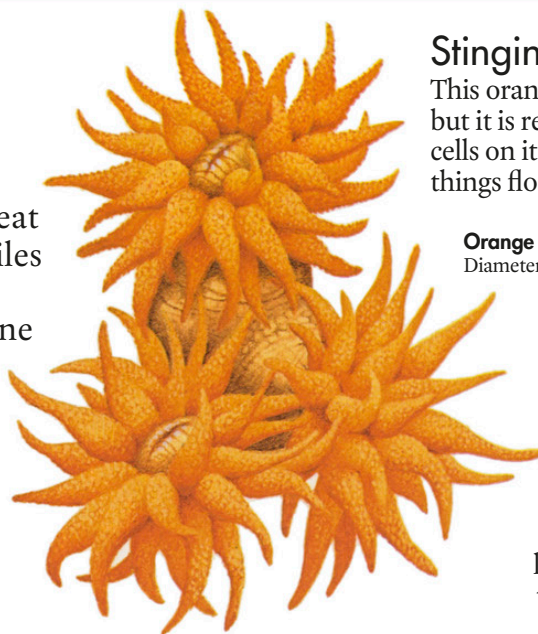


Blue-striped cleaner wrasse (*Labroides dimidiatus*)
Length: up to 5.5 in (14 cm)

Stinging tentacles

This orange cup coral looks like a plant, but it is really an animal. It uses stinging cells on its tentacles to catch tiny living things floating past in the water.

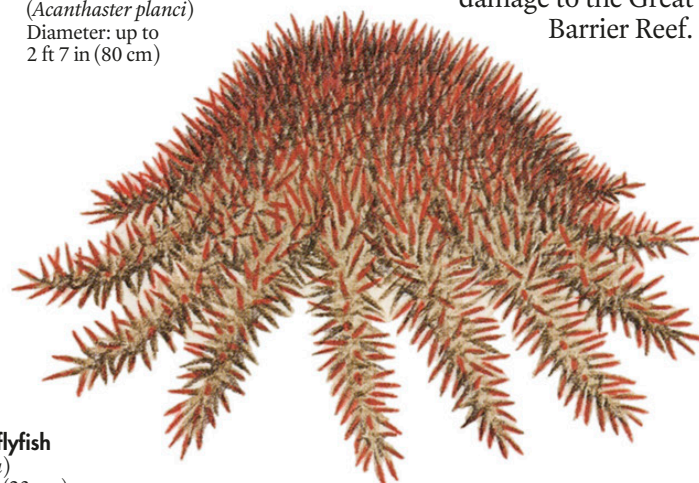
Orange cup coral (*Tubastraea coccinea*)
Diameter of each coral: up to 0.43 in (11 mm)



Reef wrecker

The crown-of-thorns starfish turns its stomach inside out and pours digestive juices over living coral to eat it, leaving only the coral's skeleton behind. One starfish can eat up to 280 sq in (1,800 sq cm) of coral in a day. These creatures have caused much damage to the Great Barrier Reef.

Crown-of-thorns starfish (*Acanthaster planci*)
Diameter: up to 2 ft 7 in (80 cm)



Free food

The cleaner wrasse gets food from other fish on the reef. It eats their parasites (animals that live on and in their bodies) and their dead scales. It stops larger fish from eating it by dancing to signal that it is a friend.

Special friends

Sea anemones have venomous tentacles that kill the small fish they eat. The clownfish is not harmed by this poison and lives among the tentacles, where it is safe from enemies. In return, the fish helps feed the anemone with waste and leftovers.



Orange clownfish (*Amphiprion percula*)
Length: up to 4 in (11 cm)

Giant carpet anemone (*Stichodactyla gigantea*)
Width: up to 2 ft 7 in (80 cm)

CAPE YORK PENINSULA

GREAT BARRIER REEF MARINE PARK



Underwater view of sea lilies, corals, and sponges.

A U S T R A L I A



When coral is not covered by sea water, it loses its bright colors.

ORANGE CLOWNFISH AND GIANT CARPET ANEMONE

THREADFIN BUTTERFLYFISH

ORANGE CUP CORAL

GREAT BARRIER REEF MARINE PARK



The Great Barrier Reef is so big that it can be seen from the Moon.

KILOMETERS
0 100 200
MILES
0 50 100